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Netflix's Environmental Impact: Sustainability Efforts and Carbon Footprint

Netflix contributes to carbon emissions through content production and streaming, but it pursues ambitious sustainability goals, including halving emissions by 2030 and offsetting the rest to support global net zero.



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QUICK SUMMARY

Netflix generates emissions mainly from content production, corporate operations, and some streaming infrastructure, while excluding viewer-side emissions from its footprint. The company has achieved 100% renewable electricity matching, pursues deep cuts in production emissions, and relies on carbon credits for its net-zero claim. Streaming itself remains a modest per-hour impact according to several studies, though global scale creates meaningful totals. You can lower your own viewing emissions with simple device and habit changes.

- ✓ Netflix aims to halve its emissions by 2030 compared to 2019 levels.
- ✓ Roughly half of Netflix's reported footprint comes from producing films and series.
- ✓ Streaming one hour of video typically emits around 55 grams of CO₂e in Europe.
- ✓ Your TV or screen usually accounts for most emissions when you watch Netflix.
- ✓ Switching to Wi-Fi, lowering resolution, and disabling autoplay reduces your impact.
- ✓ Netflix matches 100% of its electricity use with renewable energy certificates.

Where Netflix's Carbon Emissions Come From

Netflix's total carbon footprint rose almost 50 percent to 1.54 million tonnes of CO₂ in 2021, driven mainly by increased post-pandemic film production.^[1]

Roughly half of those emissions came from physical production of Netflix-branded films and series.^[1]

The remainder stemmed from corporate operations, purchased goods, cloud providers, and content delivery for streaming.^[1]

Production dominates the footprint

Content creation remains the single largest source within Netflix's accounted emissions.^[1]

In 2023, production emissions reached 313,905 metric tons CO₂e, or 35% of the reported total.^[4]

Corporate operations and cloud use

Headquarters, offices, business travel, and cloud services accounted for 61% of the 2023 footprint. ^[4]

Streaming infrastructure and data transmission made up only 5% of the reported total. ^[4]

Viewer-side emissions excluded

Netflix does not include emissions from internet transmission or the devices you use to watch. ^[1]

The company states that ISPs and device makers hold operational control over those sources. ^[1]

Netflix's Climate Targets and Actions

Netflix committed to net-zero greenhouse gas emissions by the end of 2022 and every year after. ^[1]

The company aims to cut direct and electricity-related emissions (Scope 1 & 2) by 45% by 2030. ^[1]

Netflix targets a 50% absolute emissions reduction by 2030 compared to 2019 levels. ^{[2] [6]}

100% renewable electricity matching

Since 2022 Netflix has matched 100% of its global electricity consumption with renewable energy certificates. ^{[2] [4]}

Production emission reductions

Netflix optimizes energy use, electrifies equipment, and decarbonizes remaining sources on set. ^[1]

The company replaces diesel generators with batteries, hybrid solar-battery systems, and hydrogen fuel cells where possible. ^[6]

Partnerships and innovation

Netflix co-founded the Clean Mobile Initiative to develop zero-emission mobile power for productions. ^[6]

It also uses its scale to push for innovations like mobile batteries and hydrogen units.^[1]

Critiques of Netflix's Net-Zero Approach

Netflix relies heavily on carbon credits to reach its net-zero target, a practice criticized for allowing companies to avoid full decarbonization.^[1]

Carbon credits face scrutiny over reliability, permanence, and whether they truly deliver additional reductions.^[1]

Renewable energy certificates

Netflix uses RECs to claim 100% renewable electricity, but critics argue RECs rarely add new renewable capacity.^[1]

Alternative fuels

The company adopts renewable diesel and sustainable aviation fuel, yet these still rely on biomass feedstocks that raise sustainability concerns.^[1]

Scope 3 boundary questions

Excluding viewer-side emissions leaves a major portion of the streaming value chain unaddressed in Netflix's targets.^[1]

Guidance on whether streaming companies should include these indirect emissions remains unsettled.^[1]

How Much Does Streaming Netflix Emit

One hour of video streaming generates about 55 grams of CO₂e according to a widely referenced Carbon Trust estimate.^{[2] [3] [4]}

This figure includes end-user devices, networks, and data centers but excludes content production.^[3]

In 2024 Netflix users streamed roughly 94 billion hours, leading to an estimated 5.17 million metric tons CO₂e from streaming activity.^[4]

Per-hour impact is modest

Streaming remains far less carbon-intensive than many assume when efficiency gains are considered.^[3]

Actual emissions vary by device, resolution, network type, and local electricity grid carbon intensity.^[3]

End devices drive most emissions

Your screen and home equipment usually account for the largest share of streaming-related energy use.^{[2][4]}

How You Can Lower Your Netflix Viewing Emissions

Netflix states that home viewing emissions come mostly from your electronic devices rather than streaming itself.^[7]

Small changes to your setup and habits can cut the carbon footprint of your watching.^[7]

Use Eco-mode on your TV

Switch your television to Eco-mode so it automatically saves energy during playback.^[7]

Dim the lights

Lower room lighting because screens consume more power in bright environments.^[7]

Choose the right screen size

Pick an energy-efficient TV that matches your room instead of an oversized one.^[7]

Stream over Wi-Fi

Use Wi-Fi whenever possible since mobile networks generally require extra energy.^[7]

Enable Auto Mode on mobile

Set your phone to Auto Mode to balance quality, data, and connection speed efficiently.^[7]

Frequently Asked Questions

How does Netflix help the environment?



How does Netflix impact the environment?



What does Netflix do for the environment?



How much CO₂ does one hour of Netflix streaming produce?



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